

incurred in the 1972 Easter Offensive and from the Christmas bombing of its ports. Hopes of resuming guerrilla warfare in South Vietnamese-controlled territory proved in vain.

## **North Vietnam bides its time**

By October 1973, the North Vietnamese politburo was preparing a full-scale offensive on South Vietnam. They accepted, however, that this could not happen, as long as there was still a chance that the United States would re-enter the war. Since President Nixon had assured Thieu that America would intervene if North Vietnam breached the peace accords, the North's offensive had to wait for the right moment.

The American public's frustration with the war was, by this point, reflected in Congress. In June 1973, it passed the Case-Church Amendment, which banned further military action in Asia. In November, this was followed by the War Powers Resolution, which severely restricted the president's ability to engage the United States in war without Congressional approval. Support for South Vietnam in Washington had all but vanished. Congress cut military aid to Saigon from \$1.6 billion to \$1.1 billion for 1974, while aid for 1975 was just \$700 million. In any case, by the time the War Powers Resolution was passed, Nixon's authority was all but collapsing under the Watergate scandal.



### **Nixon and Thieu**

President Thieu meets with President Nixon at San Clemente, California, in April 1973. Although Nixon renewed his promise to give military support to South Vietnam if the peace accords were violated, Congress would place severe limits on the president's ability to act.

## **Changing fortunes**

South Vietnam had inherited from the US a costly way of waging war. The impact of financial cuts on the ARVN, combined with a global oil crisis, was severe. Aircraft and helicopter use was strictly limited to save fuel. Soldiers' wages did not keep up with inflation, which undermined morale and increased the rate of desertions. South Vietnam's corruption and poor leadership came to the fore yet again, with senior officers devoting themselves to black market deals rather than attending to their men.